



Wings3D

Take Free Flight into the 3D world with Wings3D

Rossi Fernandes

The entire CG scenario has evolved since the late 90s and world class results can be achieved from pretty much anyone's computer. Open source and free 3D modelling tools such as Blender have closed the gap with commercial software. Today, we look at Wings3D, which is a 3D modelling software similar to Blender, but easier to use. You can download it from <http://www.wings3d.com> or get it from our DVD in this month's issue. There are Windows, Linux and Mac versions of Wings3D.

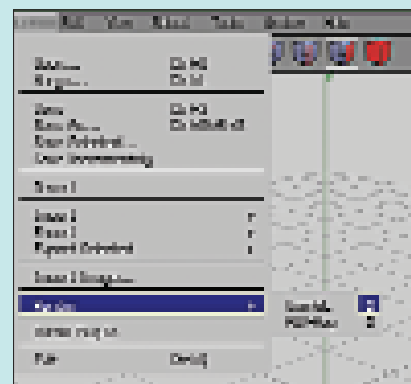
Handling The Viewport Easily

The biggest issue when you're so comfortable with commercial software such as 3ds Max or Maya is that a transition to completely different software, be it free or paid, becomes very annoying. One of the most significant changes is that you need to get used to be the way you handle the viewport and manoeuvre the camera. By default, Wings3D sets the mouse controls to invert which makes working on Wings3D even more confusing than some others.

Click on Edit > Preferences and go to the Camera tab. Click the dropdown for the Camera mode and select 3ds Max if you are comfortable using it. Click OK. Now you can use 3ds Max's keyboard and mouse configuration to handle the scene. You can also choose from any other software in the list.

Using Third-party Renderers

Contrary to popular belief, Wings3D is not a plain modelling software,



Customised renderers can be used with Wings3D

without any renderers. It has a basic default OpenGL-based renderer along with it. To render a scene, click on File > Render > OpenGL. To change the quality settings click on the block sign next to OpenGL.

You can also install custom renderers such as Povray. For that you first download and install Povray (www.povray.org). Install it into the default location. Then in Wings3D, click on File > Render > Povray to use this renderer.

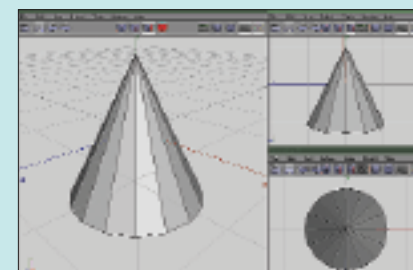
Object Management

Objects can be hidden or locked and also put into wireframe mode using the object manager—Geometry Graph

scene with decent control. The Geometry Graph in Wings3D does just that. Click on Window > Geometry Graph. You will see a small window all the objects listed. There are three tiny icons to the right of each object. The eye icon is used to hide or unhide the object. The lock icon locks or unlocks the object being interacted with, while the last icon toggles the wireframe view for the object.

Customising Views

Another obstacle with Wings3D is the lack of side views from different axes. Instead of those views, you just have one big perspective view window. Wings3D allows you to create as many windows as you need. You can resize a window by clicking and dragging the right bottom tip of the window. Each one of these windows can be set to an axis. First, create a new window by clicking on Window > New Geometry Window. Drag and drop the window to the location of your

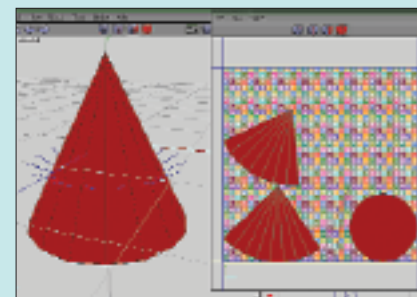


Additional views can be added and positioned within the Wings3D window

choice. Now to set a view, click on View > View Along and select the axis you want to set the camera to.

Unwrapping The Model

One of the steps involved in creating a model is the unwrapping of the model where the object is spread open, by creating cuts on key edges. The unwrapped



The unwrapped model can be used to create a texture in an image editing software

model is used to create a texture for it. There are many ways to unwrap a model, and it depends on the way the model structure has been made.

First, select the faces you want to unwrap by selecting the face mode and clicking on multiple adjoining faces. Right click and then select UV Mapping > Direct. In the window that opens, once again select the faces and right-click, choose Continue > Unfolding. Throughout these steps, you can choose different kinds of mapping to unwrap the model. Your selection will now be unwrapped.

To export the unwrapped model, right click in the UV Mapping window and click on Create Texture. Click on Window > Outliner, to enable the Outliner window. In the outliner, look for the map with the outline, right click on it and click on Make External. When prompted, enter a name for the image you want to export. Click Save.

Once you're done with creating a texture in a different application, you need to import the image by clicking on File > Import Image. Choose the image and click Open. You can see all imported images here. You can even drag and drop images into the UV Window.

Finally, it may be a bit difficult and needs a different approach to get used to, but there's no denying that in the end, you can get the same results modelling in Wings3D that you expect from a suite costing several thousands! ■

rossi.fernandes@thinkdigit.com

intimidating, but it's as easy as a copy-paste operation. Open all the tracks that you want to mix in the main window. Hit the File > New button for opening a new workspace where the final mixed track will appear. For further convenience, go to the Windows menu and choose either the Align Horizontally or Align Vertically option that will align all the windows. After you have decided on the particular sections of the tracks that will go into your mixed track, use the cursor to select them and paste them in the empty workspace. Finally, use the Mix option to combine the tracks, and you're done!

Replicate

For some specific purposes, the Replicator function is another nifty tool. If you need to extract a specific portion of audio, say about 10 seconds from a 5 minute clip the Replicator is precisely the tool you need. Or say you need to replace certain sections of the audio with repetitive sounds. Copy the audio that you need to replicate, and go to Edit > Paste Special > Replicate. Select either Copy Partials, if you want to fill the selected region completely with effects. Whole Copies option means that only an integral number of replications will occur.



Selecting the section to be replicated



The final effect

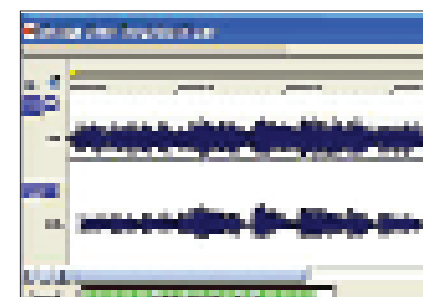
Burning

Sometimes you need a reference CD for a quick sampling of how your final effect sounds. A third-party CD burning tool such as Nero can be quite inconvenient for a quick burn. Go to Tools > Burn Track-at-Once Audio CD and select the options like burning speed. The Track-at-Once is similar to a multi-session disc, where more tracks can be added later.

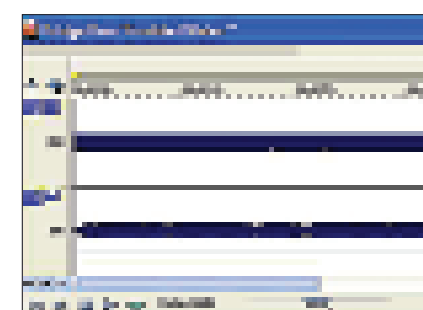
Limit Yourself

When you are mastering or editing a digital soundtrack, you need to take care of distortions. It might not sound very bad when you are wielding the scissors, but it will sound chalk-scratching-the-blackboard bad if you don't pay attention and get the final

result burned on a CD. This can be prevented by monitoring and limiting the amplitude of the audio signal. From Effects > Wave Hammer, click on the Volume Maximizer tab. There are a host of presets to choose from, while the sliders would enable you to manually adjust settings such as selecting the maximum and minimum sound levels in decibels. After you are



The waveform before using the volume control function

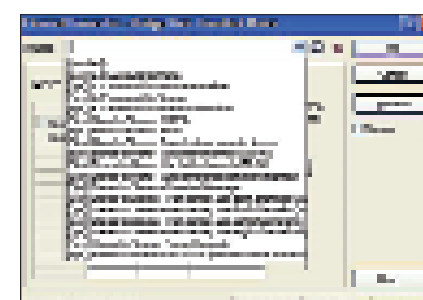


Volume control effectively adjusting the sound levels

done, click OK and you have the perfect track—nice and tidy within the limits you've specified.

Mono Sound

While stereophonic sound is all well and good, sometimes you might need to know how your fantabulous track sounds in the Mono mode. This is needed in certain applications, especially broadcasting where there are plenty of TVs and radios running on mono speakers. The stereo sounds can be changed to mono by using the Process > Channel Converter option. Apart from converting from stereo to mono,

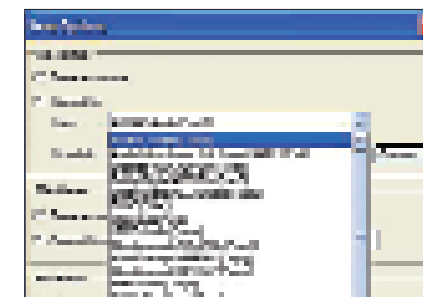


Channel converter presets

you can perform other tasks such as reversing the left and right channels and inter-mixing them.

Batch Work

In some cases, you might need to apply the same effects to multiple tracks. Such tasks call for the use of the Batch Converter. Go to Tools > Batch Converter and select the files that need you to apply the effects. Select the effects to be applied, the format in which the files are to be saved and finally hit the Run Job in the Status window to start the conversion.



Different formats available for saving

Conclusion

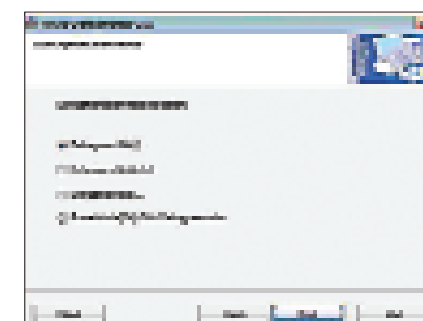
Soundforge is among the best sound editing software out there. Even though it is incredibly complex, it can be used from the absolute amateur to the polished professional. You need to practice a lot in order to master sound editing. However, with tools such as Soundforge and slight added effort, you no longer have to run to an audio parlour for your home-made videos and audio.

WINDOWS VISTA

Here is another round of Vista tips, served piping hot. As usual, backup your registry before trying any of the registry hacks.

Defrag Faster

We have talked about the importance of defragmenting your hard drive earlier, but the fact remains that defragmentation takes up too much time. However, a free tool bundle is



Options for defragmenting